For Anne Gregory

The big idea

For Anne Gregory by the Irish poet **W.B. Yeats** is a dialogue between the poet and a young girl with beautiful **yellow hair**. It explores whether people love us for our **outer beauty** or our **inner self** — and suggests that only **God** loves us for ourselves alone.

BACKGROUND

Anne Gregory was the granddaughter of **Lady Gregory**, a close friend and patron of Yeats. Yeats wrote the poem for her when she was a young girl.

Stanza by stanza

1. **The poet:** No young man, thrown into despair by those **"great honey-coloured ramparts at your ear"** (her beautiful golden hair), will ever love you for yourself alone and **not your yellow hair**.
2. **Anne's reply:** She says she can **dye her hair** — **brown, black or carrot** — so that young men will love her for herself alone and not her yellow hair.
3. **The poet again:** He heard an **old religious man** declare that he had found a text to prove that **only God** could love her for herself alone and not her yellow hair.

Themes

- **Inner vs outer beauty:** People are usually attracted first by appearance.
- **True love is rare:** Unconditional love for the soul belongs only to God.

- **Youthful idealism vs mature wisdom:** Anne believes she can change people's attitude by changing her hair; the poet knows human nature does not change.

Poetic devices

- **Dialogue form:** the poem is a conversation between the poet and Anne.
- **Metaphor: "honey-coloured ramparts"** — her hair is like the walls (ramparts) of a fort guarding her face/ears; its colour is like honey.
- **Rhyme scheme: abcbdb** in each stanza (despair/ear/hair rhyme on lines 2, 4 and 6).
- **Repetition** (refrain): "for yourself alone / And not your yellow hair".
- **Alliteration:** "**y**our **y**ellow hair"; "**y**oung men".
- **Synecdoche:** hair stands for physical beauty as a whole.

ANNE'S HAIR COLOURS

She offers to dye her hair **brown, black or carrot** — not grey or red. And it is an **old religious man** who found the text, not the poet himself.

Message and value points

- Judge people by their character and inner qualities, not looks.
- Human love is often conditional; only divine love is unconditional.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What are "honey-coloured ramparts"? Why will young men not love Anne for herself alone? How does Anne plan to solve the problem? What does the old religious man's text prove? Explain the theme of inner vs outer beauty.

Quick recap

- W.B. Yeats; dialogue with Anne Gregory.
- Honey-coloured ramparts = golden hair (metaphor).
- Anne: will dye hair brown, black or carrot.
- Only God loves you for yourself alone.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "For Anne Gregory"?
   (a) Robert Frost (b) Ogden Nash (c) W.B. Yeats (d) John Berryman
2. "Great honey-coloured ramparts at your ear" refers to Anne's
   (a) beautiful golden hair (b) earrings (c) eyes (d) face
3. Which colours did Anne say she could dye her hair?
   (a) Red, grey or white (b) Golden, silver or bronze (c) Brown, black or carrot (d) Blue, green or pink
4. According to the old religious man, who can love Anne for herself alone?
   (a) Her parents (b) A young man in despair (c) The poet (d) Only God
5. The poem is written in the form of
   (a) a ballad about a dragon (b) a sonnet (c) a dialogue between the poet and Anne (d) free verse monologue
6. What is the central theme of the poem?
   (a) Hair care (b) Inner beauty versus outer beauty (c) Religion and science (d) Love of nature
7. Why does the poet say that young men will not love Anne "for herself alone"?

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. b 7. see notes